

NOURISH — Postpartum

Phase 5 of 6 — Beyond the first year

Postpartum Week 139

DRAFT v1 — for review, not yet locked

Weekly nourishment theme

Cooking once for a household with different food habits or needs

"One meal doesn't have to become several — a shared base you finish or season differently at the edges still leaves room for your own appetite, protein and portion, without cooking a separate dish just for yourself."

Why it matters now

If your household includes people who eat differently from you — a vegetarian elder, someone who can't manage much spice, different portion needs — you may already be doing more planning at mealtimes than you're given credit for. Building meals around a shared base that you adapt at the end, rather than cooking several separate dishes, can genuinely reduce the work, but it can also quietly become a habit where your own plate is whatever's simplest or whatever's left over.

This week is about keeping your own protein, portion and calcium part of that planning, not an afterthought to everyone else's. None of this requires cooking separately for yourself — it's mostly about sequencing: setting your own portion aside, finishing your own plate's seasoning, before the rest of the household is served.

If a medical condition affects your meals

If you manage diabetes or another condition affecting blood sugar: follow your own care team's specific guidance on portions and timing — the A and B meal options here aren't matched for carbohydrate content either.

If you have PCOS: flexible, balanced eating across the week matters more than any single "PCOS diet" — there's no special curative diet required, and the general guidance in this series applies to you too.

If you take levothyroxine: follow your prescribed timing around meals, calcium-rich foods, and calcium or iron supplements — ask your pharmacist if you're unsure about spacing.

If you're cooking a reduced-spice or reduced-salt version of a dish for someone else in the household: your own portion doesn't need to match theirs unless you have your own reason to eat that way — season or finish your own plate separately once the shared base is cooked.

These notes are general starting points, not condition-specific menus — the meal options below aren't matched to any particular condition's nutrient or carbohydrate targets. Individual guidance from your own care team always takes precedence.

If you eat meat, fish, or eggs

Meat, fish and eggs can all sit comfortably in a regular week's meals here. If you are pregnant or breastfeeding and eat fish, FDA/EPA guidance recommends two to three adult servings weekly from its "Best Choices" list — about 113 g per serving before cooking. Follow local advisories. This is an option for fish eaters, not a requirement to add fish.

Using the meals below

Choose either option, not both — these are alternatives, not two separate meals. Repeating a combination you already enjoyed earlier in the week is completely fine. If nothing here appeals or you'd rather keep it simple, reheated dal, rice and curd is an option if it suits your dietary needs and any care plan you follow. The "if you're still hungry" suggestions are suggestions, not limits — adjust everything to your own appetite; this week's meals are

meant to be adequate, not restrictive. The "A" options are vegetarian, prepared with vegetable stock or water rather than meat or fish stock, including this week's regional dishes.

Portions below are adjustable starting points, not maximum allowances — scale to your own appetite, activity and any care plan you follow. A cup means a standard 240ml measuring cup. Unless a dish says otherwise: rice or another cooked grain eaten on its own is one level cup (about 150g); a dal, bean or lentil curry eaten as its own dish is three-quarters of a cup cooked (about 150g); a roti is one medium piece; toast is 2 slices. In a mixed rice or grain dish, the meat, fish, paneer or legume component is about 75-100g of that ingredient (roughly a palm-sized piece, or half a cup of cooked legumes), counted separately from the grain itself.

Paneer, tofu, meat or fish eaten as a dish's main item is 75-100g cooked (a palm-sized piece), or two eggs — these are different foods with different nutrient content, and are not nutritionally interchangeable just because they share a similar portion size. Curd or milk is a small bowl or glass (150-200ml); a cooked vegetable side is about a cup; nuts or seeds used as a topping are about a tablespoon (roughly 10-15g).

The meals contribute different nutrients across the day; each individual meal or snack does not need to include every food group. Choose varied meals through the day and include a dependable protein source and a dependable calcium source at more than one meal — curd, milk or paneer — rather than relying on trace amounts in mixed dishes or an optional extra. If you avoid dairy, include measured portions of calcium-fortified alternatives or calcium-set tofu, checking the label. Adults generally need about 1,000 mg of calcium a day, including while breastfeeding — a single measured serving is a helpful building block, not the whole day's requirement on its own. Food choices alone don't rule out a need for supplementation — ask your own clinician what's right for you.

This week's meals draw on Konkani Goud Saraswat Brahmin home cooking (sol kadhi, ambat, upkari, dalitoy, khotto, and similar). If a regional dish is unfamiliar or unavailable, choose a familiar alternative with a similar nutritional role: dal or beans for a legume dish, a suitable protein source for a protein dish, and vegetables for a vegetable side. Keep the grain portion and any planned calcium source. These swaps are not nutritionally identical.

Day 1 — Anchor

Cooking for a household where people eat differently — a vegetarian elder, someone who can't take much spice, different portion needs — often means building meals around everyone else first. A shared base you adapt at the end, rather than cooking multiple separate dishes, can save real effort while still leaving room for your own plate to be complete.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Sanna polo, soft rice-and-coconut pancake (2 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Dalitoy, plain toor dal (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked toor dal) with rice (1 cup cooked) and an upkari (stir-fried cabbage)
- B. Kori ambat, Konkani-style chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and an upkari (stir-fried cabbage)

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted cashews (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a beans upkari
- B. Paneer-and-tomato curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans upkari

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 2 — Cooking one base, then splitting it at the end

A shared vegetable or dal base — cooked plain first, then divided before adding chilli, extra spice or a non-vegetarian addition to individual portions — is often quicker than starting several dishes from scratch. Your own portion can be the one that gets a full protein addition, rather than automatically becoming the plainest one on the table.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Neer dosa (3 pieces) with a coconut chutney and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Ambat, coconut-based vegetable curry (1 cup) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a chana dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Konkani fish curry (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and an ambat, coconut-based vegetable curry (1 cup)

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut papaya
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup) and a bhindi upkari
- B. Egg curry, Konkani-style (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bhindi upkari

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 3 — Protecting your own portion when food is served family-style

Family-style serving can mean the person cooking, and often serving, ends up eating whatever's left rather than a planned portion. Setting your own plate aside before the rest of the household starts serving themselves is a small, practical habit, not a sign you're being unfair to anyone else at the table.

Worth knowing: When a meal is served from shared serving dishes rather than individually plated, it's easy for your own portion to end up smaller than planned, especially once everyone else has been served first. Plating your own protein and grain portion before the dish goes to the table, or serving yourself early rather than last, is a practical way to make sure your plate is complete too.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Sanna polo with grated coconut (2 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-tomato omelette (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Dalitoy with pumpkin (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked toor dal) with rice (1 cup cooked)
- B. Kori ambat (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cauliflower upkari

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a guava
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a toor dal (3/4 cup) and a cauliflower upkari
- B. Paneer-and-peas curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a carrot upkari

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 4 — Adjusting spice or salt for others without under-serving yourself

Cooking blander for a family member who needs it — an elder, someone with a digestive condition — doesn't mean your own plate has to match. Season and finish your own portion separately once the base is cooked, rather than eating the same reduced-spice, reduced-salt version out of habit when it isn't what you actually need.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Suji upma with mixed vegetables (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-spinach bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Ambat with raw banana (1 cup) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a moong dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Kori ambat (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans upkari

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a pear
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted walnuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Sanna polo (2 pieces) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a spinach upkari
- B. Egg curry, Konkani-style (2 eggs) with sanna polo (2 pieces) and a spinach upkari

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 5 — Big-batch communal cooking — a puja, a gathering

Cooking in large quantities for a gathering or a puja day is a different scale of effort, and it's easy to end up eating irregularly, or mostly leftovers, while everyone else is served properly. Setting aside your own plate, with a full portion of whatever protein is being served, before the serving starts is worth doing on these days especially.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Neer dosa with jaggery (3 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-vegetable sandwich (2 eggs, 2 slices bread) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Khotto, steamed vegetable-and-lentil cakes (2 pieces) with an ambat (1 cup)
- B. Khotto, steamed vegetable-and-lentil cakes (2 pieces) with a Kori ambat, Konkani-style chicken curry (100g chicken)

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with an orange
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted makhana (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with an urad dal (3/4 cup) and a carrot upkari
- B. Konkani fish ambot-tik, tangy-spicy fish curry (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a carrot upkari

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 6 — The pattern across your week matters, not one meal

Some days, cooking for a mixed household still means your own plate ends up smaller or simpler than planned — that's a realistic part of running a kitchen for more than one person, not a failure to manage it perfectly. What matters is that across most of the week, your own portion, protein and calcium are getting the same planning as everyone else's.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Suji upma with grated carrot (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-onion bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Dalitoy (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked toor dal) with rice (1 cup cooked) and an upkari (stir-fried beans and carrot)
- B. Kori ambat (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and an upkari (stir-fried beans and carrot)

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut watermelon
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few dates

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Moong dal-and-vegetable khichdi (1 1/2 cups total, made with a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong dal, plus carrots and peas) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg curry, Konkani-style (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage upkari

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 7 — A repeat-favourites day

No forced choices today. Day 1's combination is repeated below as a ready option — or swap in whichever meals from earlier in the week worked best for you.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Sanna polo, soft rice-and-coconut pancake (2 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Dalitoy, plain toor dal (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked toor dal) with rice (1 cup cooked) and an upkari (stir-fried cabbage)
- B. Kori ambat, Konkani-style chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and an upkari (stir-fried cabbage)

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted cashews (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a beans upkari
- B. Paneer-and-tomato curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans upkari

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Was there a moment this week you deliberately set your own portion aside before serving everyone else — and how did that change the rest of your day?

Gentle weekly reflection

What's one small habit from this week — a food, a routine — that felt worth keeping, without needing to overhaul everything at once?

Looking ahead

The next set of weeks continues this series' steady, one-topic-at-a-time approach to your own nutrition and wellbeing.

Food safety basics

- Cook meat, poultry and fish to a safe internal temperature rather than judging by colour alone — check with a food thermometer where practical: whole cuts of beef, pork, veal or lamb to at least 63°C, followed by three minutes' rest; ground meat to at least 71°C; poultry, including ground poultry, to at least 74°C; and fish to at least 63°C. Avoid runny yolks.
- Use pasteurized dairy only.
- Wash fruits and vegetables thoroughly before eating.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. Boiling can reduce microbial risk, but it does not remove fluoride or other dissolved chemicals. If fluoride or another chemical contaminant is a concern, use a water source or treatment method confirmed as suitable by the local water authority or a recognised laboratory.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding or could be pregnant, unless your healthcare team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding, and no amount of alcohol is known to be safe if you're pregnant or could be. If you choose to drink while breastfeeding and not pregnant, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose fish from the FDA/EPA "Best Choices" list and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.
- When cooking a shared base for a household with different needs, plate your own protein and grain portion before finishing the dish for everyone else, so your own plate stays a planned, complete meal rather than whatever's left afterward.

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Phase 5 of 6 — Beyond the first year

Postpartum Week 140

DRAFT v1 — for review, not yet locked

Weekly nourishment theme

Eating well on badly-slept nights and the tired days after

"A rough night makes the pull toward something quick and sugary feel stronger than usual — that's a real physiological response, not a lack of willpower. Having a few steady, low-effort options ready matters more on these days than on any other."

Why it matters now

Broken or short sleep doesn't just leave you tired — it measurably shifts appetite hormones, tilting hunger toward quick, energy-dense food and away from the effort of cooking or planning a balanced meal. If you notice yourself reaching harder for sugar or skipping meals after a bad night, that's a recognised response to sleep loss, not a personal failing.

This week focuses on having a few steady, low-effort options ready for the days that follow a rough night — food that needs little preparation, still includes protein, and doesn't require willpower you may not have to spare that day.

If a medical condition affects your meals

If you manage diabetes or another condition affecting blood sugar: follow your own care team's specific guidance on portions and timing — the A and B meal options here aren't matched for carbohydrate content either.

If you have PCOS: flexible, balanced eating across the week matters more than any single "PCOS diet" — there's no special curative diet required, and the general guidance in this series applies to you too.

If you take levothyroxine: follow your prescribed timing around meals, calcium-rich foods, and calcium or iron supplements — ask your pharmacist if you're unsure about spacing.

If poor sleep is a frequent, ongoing pattern rather than occasional: it's worth mentioning to your own healthcare team — this week's suggestions are about eating through tired days, not a substitute for addressing persistent sleep problems.

These notes are general starting points, not condition-specific menus — the meal options below aren't matched to any particular condition's nutrient or carbohydrate targets. Individual guidance from your own care team always takes precedence.

If you eat meat, fish, or eggs

Meat, fish and eggs can all sit comfortably in a regular week's meals here. If you are pregnant or breastfeeding and eat fish, FDA/EPA guidance recommends two to three adult servings weekly from its "Best Choices" list — about 113 g per serving before cooking. Follow local advisories. This is an option for fish eaters, not a requirement to add fish.

Using the meals below

Choose either option, not both — these are alternatives, not two separate meals. Repeating a combination you already enjoyed earlier in the week is completely fine. If nothing here appeals or you'd rather keep it simple, reheated dal, rice and curd is an option if it suits your dietary needs and any care plan you follow. The "if you're still hungry" suggestions are suggestions, not limits — adjust everything to your own appetite; this week's meals are

meant to be adequate, not restrictive. The "A" options are vegetarian, prepared with vegetable stock or water rather than meat or fish stock, including this week's regional dishes.

Portions below are adjustable starting points, not maximum allowances — scale to your own appetite, activity and any care plan you follow. A cup means a standard 240ml measuring cup. Unless a dish says otherwise: rice or another cooked grain eaten on its own is one level cup (about 150g); a dal, bean or lentil curry eaten as its own dish is three-quarters of a cup cooked (about 150g); a roti is one medium piece; toast is 2 slices. In a mixed rice or grain dish, the meat, fish, paneer or legume component is about 75-100g of that ingredient (roughly a palm-sized piece, or half a cup of cooked legumes), counted separately from the grain itself.

Paneer, tofu, meat or fish eaten as a dish's main item is 75-100g cooked (a palm-sized piece), or two eggs — these are different foods with different nutrient content, and are not nutritionally interchangeable just because they share a similar portion size. Curd or milk is a small bowl or glass (150-200ml); a cooked vegetable side is about a cup; nuts or seeds used as a topping are about a tablespoon (roughly 10-15g).

The meals contribute different nutrients across the day; each individual meal or snack does not need to include every food group. Choose varied meals through the day and include a dependable protein source and a dependable calcium source at more than one meal — curd, milk or paneer — rather than relying on trace amounts in mixed dishes or an optional extra. If you avoid dairy, include measured portions of calcium-fortified alternatives or calcium-set tofu, checking the label. Adults generally need about 1,000 mg of calcium a day, including while breastfeeding — a single measured serving is a helpful building block, not the whole day's requirement on its own. Food choices alone don't rule out a need for supplementation — ask your own clinician what's right for you.

This week's meals draw on Assamese home cooking (tenga, khar, pitika, masor jool, and similar). If a regional dish is unfamiliar or unavailable, choose a familiar alternative with a similar nutritional role: dal or beans for a legume dish, a suitable protein source for a protein dish, and vegetables for a vegetable side. Keep the grain portion and any planned calcium source. These swaps are not nutritionally identical.

Day 1 — Anchor

Poor sleep genuinely changes appetite — it tends to increase hunger signals and cravings for quick sugar or refined carbs, while making protein-rich or effortful food feel less appealing. Recognising that pull as a real response to short sleep, rather than a failure of discipline, is the starting point for working with it instead of against it.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Chira pitika, flattened rice mashed with curd and banana (1 cup) with a boiled egg
- B. Peanut butter toast (2 slices) with a glass of milk (200ml) and a banana

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Khar, raw papaya and lentil dish (1 cup) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a masoor dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Paneer-and-tomato curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a khar vegetable side

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted chana (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a pumpkin sabzi
- B. Chicken curry, Assamese-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a pumpkin sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 2 — The quick-sugar pull, and a steadier alternative

On very little sleep, the easiest thing to reach for is often something sweet and fast — and that's fine occasionally. But a quick sugar hit tends to be followed by a sharper energy dip an hour or two later, which can make an already tired day feel worse. Pairing something sweet with a bit of protein or fibre — fruit with nuts, rather than fruit alone — tends to hold energy steadier.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Suji upma with vegetables (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Bor dal, split gram with vegetables (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana dal) with rice (1 cup cooked)
- B. Assamese fish tenga, tangy fish curry (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bhindi pitika

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut apple
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a toor dal (3/4 cup) and a cabbage pitika
- B. Egg curry, Assamese-style (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage pitika

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 3 — No-cook and low-effort options for the hardest days

Some days genuinely don't have the energy for a stove. Curd with fruit and nuts, a boiled-egg sandwich, or a glass of milk with roasted chana are all complete-enough options that need little or no cooking, and they're worth treating as legitimate meals, not just stopgaps.

Worth knowing: On days when even simple cooking feels like too much, having two or three no-cook or minimal-effort combinations already in mind — rather than deciding from scratch while exhausted — can be the difference between eating something adequate and skipping meals or reaching for whatever's fastest.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Chira with curd and jaggery (1 cup flattened rice, measured dry before soaking; 150g curd)
- B. Egg sandwich (2 eggs, 2 slices bread) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup) and a khar vegetable side
- B. Chicken curry, Assamese-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans pitika

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a pear
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted walnuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a spinach pitika
- B. Paneer-and-tomato curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach pitika

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 4 — Protein at breakfast matters more, not less, on tired mornings

It's tempting to skip breakfast or grab only something sweet on a groggy morning, but a protein-containing breakfast tends to blunt the mid-morning crash that makes an already tired day feel harder. It doesn't need to be elaborate — eggs, curd, or a glass of milk alongside whatever's quickest all count.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Pitika, mashed potato with mustard oil and vegetables (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Khar with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and rice (1 cup cooked)
- B. Egg curry, Assamese-style (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a lauki sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a guava
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few dates

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with an urad dal (3/4 cup) and a carrot sabzi
- B. Chicken curry, Assamese-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 5 — Hydration and caffeine on very tired days

It's easy to under-drink water on an exhausting day and reach for extra caffeine instead. A little caffeine is fine within the usual limit, but it isn't a substitute for water, and dehydration itself can make tiredness and headaches worse. Keeping a water bottle within reach through the day is a small, low-effort habit worth keeping even when everything else feels like too much.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Luchi, deep-fried flatbread (2 pieces) with an aloo sabzi and a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg-and-vegetable omelette (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Bor dal with lauki (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana dal) with rice (1 cup cooked)

B. Assamese fish curry (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cauliflower pitika

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with an orange

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted makhana (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup) and a bhindi sabzi

B. Paneer-and-peas curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bhindi sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 6 — The pattern across broken nights matters, not one bad day

A single badly-slept night and the sluggish day after it won't undo a generally steady pattern of eating. What tends to matter more is whether the tired days start stacking up into a habit of skipped meals and mostly sugar — worth noticing if that starts happening, and worth being gentle with yourself about if it does happen sometimes.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Suji upma with grated carrot (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg-and-onion bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a khar vegetable side

B. Chicken curry, Assamese-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut watermelon

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted cashews (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Moong dal-and-vegetable khichdi (1 1/2 cups total, made with a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong dal, plus carrots and peas) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg curry, Assamese-style (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 7 — A repeat-favourites day

No forced choices today. Day 1's combination is repeated below as a ready option — or swap in whichever meals from earlier in the week worked best for you.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Chira pitika, flattened rice mashed with curd and banana (1 cup) with a boiled egg

B. Peanut butter toast (2 slices) with a glass of milk (200ml) and a banana

Lunch — choose one:

A. Khar, raw papaya and lentil dish (1 cup) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a masoor dal (3/4 cup)

B. Paneer-and-tomato curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a khar vegetable side

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted chana (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a pumpkin sabzi

B. Chicken curry, Assamese-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a pumpkin sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Which low-effort combination from this week would you keep on hand for the next rough night, even without thinking it through again?

Gentle weekly reflection

What's one small habit from this week — a food, a routine — that felt worth keeping, without needing to overhaul everything at once?

Looking ahead

The next set of weeks continues this series' steady, one-topic-at-a-time approach to your own nutrition and wellbeing.

Food safety basics

- Cook meat, poultry and fish to a safe internal temperature rather than judging by colour alone — check with a food thermometer where practical: whole cuts of beef, pork, veal or lamb to at least 63°C, followed by three minutes' rest; ground meat to at least 71°C; poultry, including ground poultry, to at least 74°C; and fish to at least 63°C. Avoid runny yolks.
- Use pasteurized dairy only.
- Wash fruits and vegetables thoroughly before eating.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. Boiling can reduce microbial risk, but it does not remove fluoride or other dissolved chemicals. If fluoride or another chemical contaminant is a concern, use a water source or treatment method confirmed as suitable by the local water authority or a recognised laboratory.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding or could be pregnant, unless your healthcare team advises otherwise — this limit still applies on tired days, even when the pull toward an extra cup is stronger.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding, and no amount of alcohol is known to be safe if you're pregnant or could be. If you choose to drink while breastfeeding and not pregnant, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose fish from the FDA/EPA "Best Choices" list and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.

NOURISH — Postpartum

Phase 5 of 6 — Beyond the first year

Postpartum Week 141

DRAFT v1 — for review, not yet locked

Weekly nourishment theme

Eating well while travelling with a baby or toddler

"Travel days genuinely disrupt routine — but a few portable, non-perishable staples packed ahead of time mean a delayed train or a long drive doesn't have to become a day of skipped meals."

Why it matters now

Travelling with a baby or toddler — whether it's a short trip to family or something longer — tends to disrupt routine more than almost anything else, and your own meals are often the first casualty of a packed itinerary or a delayed connection. It's easy to end up running on packaged snacks and whatever's available at the last minute.

A little planning ahead — a few portable staples, a sense of what's safe to eat once you arrive, and permission to eat at odd times if the schedule demands it — can keep travel days from becoming days where you barely eat.

If a medical condition affects your meals

If you manage diabetes or another condition affecting blood sugar: follow your own care team's specific guidance on portions and timing — the A and B meal options here aren't matched for carbohydrate content either.

If you have PCOS: flexible, balanced eating across the week matters more than any single "PCOS diet" — there's no special curative diet required, and the general guidance in this series applies to you too.

If you take levothyroxine: follow your prescribed timing around meals, calcium-rich foods, and calcium or iron supplements — ask your pharmacist if you're unsure about spacing, especially if a travel schedule shifts your usual medication timing.

If you're travelling somewhere with limited access to food you'd normally eat: carrying a few days' worth of any prescribed supplements, and checking with your care team ahead of a longer trip, is worth doing before you leave.

These notes are general starting points, not condition-specific menus — the meal options below aren't matched to any particular condition's nutrient or carbohydrate targets. Individual guidance from your own care team always takes precedence.

If you eat meat, fish, or eggs

Meat, fish and eggs can all sit comfortably in a regular week's meals here. If you are pregnant or breastfeeding and eat fish, FDA/EPA guidance recommends two to three adult servings weekly from its "Best Choices" list — about 113 g per serving before cooking. Follow local advisories. This is an option for fish eaters, not a requirement to add fish.

Using the meals below

Choose either option, not both — these are alternatives, not two separate meals. Repeating a combination you already enjoyed earlier in the week is completely fine. If nothing here appeals or you'd rather keep it simple, reheated dal, rice and curd is an option if it suits your dietary needs and any care plan you follow. The "if you're still hungry" suggestions are suggestions, not limits — adjust everything to your own appetite; this week's meals are meant to be adequate, not restrictive. The "A" options are vegetarian, prepared with vegetable stock or water rather than meat or fish stock, including this week's regional dishes.

Portions below are adjustable starting points, not maximum allowances — scale to your own appetite, activity and any care plan you follow. A cup means a standard 240ml measuring cup. Unless a dish says otherwise: rice or another cooked grain eaten on its own is one level cup (about 150g); a dal, bean or lentil curry eaten as its own dish is three-quarters of a cup cooked (about 150g); a roti is one medium piece; toast is 2 slices. In a mixed rice or grain dish, the meat, fish, paneer or legume component is about 75-100g of that ingredient (roughly a palm-sized piece, or half a cup of cooked legumes), counted separately from the grain itself.

Paneer, tofu, meat or fish eaten as a dish's main item is 75-100g cooked (a palm-sized piece), or two eggs — these are different foods with different nutrient content, and are not nutritionally interchangeable just because they share a similar portion size. Curd or milk is a small bowl or glass (150-200ml); a cooked vegetable side is about a cup; nuts or seeds used as a topping are about a tablespoon (roughly 10-15g).

The meals contribute different nutrients across the day; each individual meal or snack does not need to include every food group. Choose varied meals through the day and include a dependable protein source and a dependable calcium source at more than one meal — curd, milk or paneer — rather than relying on trace amounts in mixed dishes or an optional extra. If you avoid dairy, include measured portions of calcium-fortified alternatives or calcium-set tofu, checking the label. Adults generally need about 1,000 mg of calcium a day, including while breastfeeding — a single measured serving is a helpful building block, not the whole day's requirement on its own. Food choices alone don't rule out a need for supplementation — ask your own clinician what's right for you.

This week's meals draw on Bengali home cooking (shukto, jhol, ghonto, chorchori, and similar). If a regional dish is unfamiliar or unavailable, choose a familiar alternative with a similar nutritional role: dal or beans for a legume dish, a suitable protein source for a protein dish, and vegetables for a vegetable side. Keep the grain portion and any planned calcium source. These swaps are not nutritionally identical.

Day 1 — Anchor

Travel with a young child rarely goes exactly to plan, and mealtimes are often the first thing to slip. Packing a few sturdy, non-perishable items — roasted chana, dry fruit, whole fruit, crackers — before you leave means there's something reliable to eat even if a planned stop gets missed.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Luchi, deep-fried flatbread (2 pieces) with an aloo dum and a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Shukto, mixed vegetable stew (1 cup) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a masoor dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Paneer-and-tomato curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a shukto (1 cup)

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted chana (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a cabbage ghonto
- B. Chicken curry, Bengali-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage ghonto

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 2 — Packing food for transit

For a train, flight or long drive, food that survives room temperature for several hours is what matters most — think roasted nuts and seeds, dry fruit, whole fruit that doesn't bruise easily, plain crackers, and dry snacks rather than anything with dairy, egg or gravy that needs refrigeration. A flask of water and a reusable bottle you can refill are worth carrying regardless of what else you pack.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Chirer pulao, flattened rice with vegetables (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Peanut butter toast (2 slices) with a glass of milk (200ml) and a banana

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Cholar dal, Bengal gram dal with coconut (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana dal) with rice (1 cup cooked)
- B. Bengali fish curry, home-packed (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans chorchori

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut apple
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a toor dal (3/4 cup) and a spinach ghonto
- B. Egg curry, Bengali-style (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach ghonto

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 3 — Navigating unfamiliar food away from home

Eating away from your usual kitchen doesn't mean eating worse — most towns and cities have some version of dal, rice, roti and a cooked vegetable available, which covers the basics even when nothing else about the trip is familiar. Sticking to freshly cooked, hot food and reliable water sources is the main precaution worth keeping in mind.

Worth knowing: In an unfamiliar place, freshly cooked hot food from a reasonably busy, visibly clean place is generally a safer bet than something that's been sitting out, and bottled or reliably treated water is worth prioritising over tap water you're unsure of, especially while breastfeeding.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Luchi with cholar dal (2 pieces, 1 cup dal) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-tomato omelette (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup) and a shukto (1 cup)
- B. Chicken curry, Bengali-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cauliflower chorchori

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a guava
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few dates

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a carrot ghonto
- B. Paneer-and-peas curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a carrot ghonto

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 4 — Keeping meals roughly regular despite a disrupted schedule

Travel days often mean meals happen later, earlier, or out of order compared to your usual pattern — that's fine occasionally, but going long stretches without eating because the timing is off can leave you running on empty by evening. A packed snack eaten at the "wrong" time is still better than waiting until you're overly hungry to eat anything at all.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Suji upma with vegetables (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Cholar dal with lauki (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked chana dal) with rice (1 cup cooked)
- B. Egg curry, Bengali-style (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bhindi chorchori

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a pear
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted walnuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with an urad dal (3/4 cup) and a lauki ghonto
- B. Chicken curry, Bengali-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a lauki ghonto

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 5 — Breastfeeding or expressing on the move

If you're breastfeeding or carrying expressed milk while travelling, staying hydrated and eating regularly both matter more, not less, on a demanding travel day. Carrying a refillable water bottle and a couple of protein-containing snacks alongside your usual feeding supplies is worth building into your packing routine.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Chirer pulao with peanuts (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg-and-vegetable sandwich (2 eggs, 2 slices bread) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Shukto with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and rice (1 cup cooked)

B. Bengali fish jhol (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cauliflower ghonto

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with an orange

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted makhana (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup) and a bhindi ghonto

B. Egg curry, Bengali-style (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bhindi ghonto

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 6 — Coming home and settling back into your usual pattern

After a trip, it can take a day or two to feel back on your usual eating rhythm, and that's completely normal.

Restocking your kitchen with a few staples — dal, rice, curd, eggs — before you're too tired to think about it makes that first day home easier than arriving to an empty fridge.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Suji upma with grated carrot (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg-and-onion bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a shukto (1 cup)

B. Chicken curry, Bengali-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage chorchori

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut watermelon

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted cashews (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Moong dal-and-vegetable khichdi (1 1/2 cups total, made with a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong dal, plus carrots and peas) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg curry, Bengali-style (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach chorchori

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 7 — A repeat-favourites day

No forced choices today. Day 1's combination is repeated below as a ready option — or swap in whichever meals from earlier in the week worked best for you.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Luchi, deep-fried flatbread (2 pieces) with an aloo dum and a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Boiled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Shukto, mixed vegetable stew (1 cup) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a masoor dal (3/4 cup)

B. Paneer-and-tomato curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a shukto (1 cup)

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted chana (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a cabbage ghonto

B. Chicken curry, Bengali-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage ghonto

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

What would you pack differently next time you travel, based on what worked or didn't this week?

Gentle weekly reflection

What's one small habit from this week — a food, a routine — that felt worth keeping, without needing to overhaul everything at once?

Looking ahead

The next set of weeks continues this series' steady, one-topic-at-a-time approach to your own nutrition and wellbeing.

Food safety basics

- Cook meat, poultry and fish to a safe internal temperature rather than judging by colour alone — check with a food thermometer where practical: whole cuts of beef, pork, veal or lamb to at least 63°C, followed by three minutes' rest; ground meat to at least 71°C; poultry, including ground poultry, to at least 74°C; and fish to at least 63°C. Avoid runny yolks.
- Use pasteurized dairy only.
- Wash fruits and vegetables thoroughly before eating.
- Use reliably safe drinking water, especially while travelling. Boiling can reduce microbial risk, but it does not remove fluoride or other dissolved chemicals. If you're unsure of a local water source, bottled or reliably treated water is the safer choice.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding or could be pregnant, unless your healthcare team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding, and no amount of alcohol is known to be safe if you're pregnant or could be. If you choose to drink while breastfeeding and not pregnant, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm — and while travelling, avoid perishable items (dairy, egg, gravy-based food) that have been sitting at room temperature for more than two hours, or one hour above 32°C.
- Choose fish from the FDA/EPA "Best Choices" list and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.
- When eating away from home, freshly cooked hot food from a reasonably busy, visibly clean establishment is generally a safer choice than food that has been sitting out or held at room temperature for an unknown length of time.

NOURISH — Postpartum

Phase 5 of 6 — Beyond the first year

Postpartum Week 142

DRAFT v1 — for review, not yet locked

Weekly nourishment theme

Your own eating as breastfeeding frequency changes

"As nursing becomes less frequent, your appetite and calorie needs may shift too — that's a normal adjustment, not something to manage anxiously, and the calcium and protein habits worth keeping are worth keeping regardless of how often you're nursing."

Why it matters now

If breastfeeding is becoming less frequent in your household — whether that's a deliberate choice, your child's own lead, or simply how things are settling by this stage — your own appetite and calorie needs may shift along with it. This is a normal, expected adjustment, not something that needs managing anxiously or correcting.

This week is about letting your eating settle to match your actual hunger during this transition, while keeping the calcium and protein habits that were serving you well, since those matter for your own long-term health well beyond how often you're nursing.

If a medical condition affects your meals

If you manage diabetes or another condition affecting blood sugar: follow your own care team's specific guidance on portions and timing — the A and B meal options here aren't matched for carbohydrate content either.

If you have PCOS: flexible, balanced eating across the week matters more than any single "PCOS diet" — there's no special curative diet required, and the general guidance in this series applies to you too.

If you take levothyroxine: follow your prescribed timing around meals, calcium-rich foods, and calcium or iron supplements — ask your pharmacist if you're unsure about spacing.

If your appetite drop feels severe, persistent, or comes with other symptoms that worry you: mention it to your healthcare team rather than assuming it will simply pass on its own.

These notes are general starting points, not condition-specific menus — the meal options below aren't matched to any particular condition's nutrient or carbohydrate targets. Individual guidance from your own care team always takes precedence.

If you eat meat, fish, or eggs

Meat, fish and eggs can all sit comfortably in a regular week's meals here. If you are pregnant or breastfeeding and eat fish, FDA/EPA guidance recommends two to three adult servings weekly from its "Best Choices" list — about 113 g per serving before cooking. Follow local advisories. This is an option for fish eaters, not a requirement to add fish.

Using the meals below

Choose either option, not both — these are alternatives, not two separate meals. Repeating a combination you already enjoyed earlier in the week is completely fine. If nothing here appeals or you'd rather keep it simple, reheated dal, rice and curd is an option if it suits your dietary needs and any care plan you follow. The "if you're still hungry" suggestions are suggestions, not limits — adjust everything to your own appetite; this week's meals are meant to be adequate, not restrictive. The "A" options are vegetarian, prepared with vegetable stock or water rather than meat or fish stock, including this week's regional dishes.

Portions below are adjustable starting points, not maximum allowances — scale to your own appetite, activity and any care plan you follow. A cup means a standard 240ml measuring cup. Unless a dish says otherwise: rice or another cooked grain eaten on its own is one level cup (about 150g); a dal, bean or lentil curry eaten as its own dish is three-quarters of a cup cooked (about 150g); a roti is one medium piece; toast is 2 slices. In a mixed rice or grain dish, the meat, fish, paneer or legume component is about 75-100g of that ingredient (roughly a palm-sized piece, or half a cup of cooked legumes), counted separately from the grain itself.

Paneer, tofu, meat or fish eaten as a dish's main item is 75-100g cooked (a palm-sized piece), or two eggs — these are different foods with different nutrient content, and are not nutritionally interchangeable just because they share a similar portion size. Curd or milk is a small bowl or glass (150-200ml); a cooked vegetable side is about a cup; nuts or seeds used as a topping are about a tablespoon (roughly 10-15g).

The meals contribute different nutrients across the day; each individual meal or snack does not need to include every food group. Choose varied meals through the day and include a dependable protein source and a dependable calcium source at more than one meal — curd, milk or paneer — rather than relying on trace amounts in mixed dishes or an optional extra. If you avoid dairy, include measured portions of calcium-fortified alternatives or calcium-set tofu, checking the label. Adults generally need about 1,000 mg of calcium a day — a single measured serving is a helpful building block, not the whole day's requirement on its own. Food choices alone don't rule out a need for supplementation — ask your own clinician what's right for you.

This week's meals draw on Odia home cooking (dalma, santula, besara, machha jhola, and similar). If a regional dish is unfamiliar or unavailable, choose a familiar alternative with a similar nutritional role: dal or beans for a legume dish, a suitable protein source for a protein dish, and vegetables for a vegetable side. Keep the grain portion and any planned calcium source. These swaps are not nutritionally identical.

Day 1 — Anchor

As breastfeeding frequency reduces — whether gradually or by your child's own choice — your appetite may genuinely change too, sometimes dropping noticeably. That's a normal physiological adjustment, not a sign anything is wrong, and it's fine to let your intake settle to match your actual hunger rather than eating to a fixed target from earlier months.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Poda pitha, fermented rice cake (2 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Dalma, dal with vegetables (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked toor dal) with rice (1 cup cooked)
- B. Paneer-and-tomato curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a dalma (1 cup)

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a cabbage santula
- B. Chicken curry, Odia-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage santula

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 2 — Keeping the habits that were serving you well

If nursing has been prompting you to keep a glass of milk or a bowl of curd within reach, or to eat a bit more regularly through the day, those habits are worth keeping even as feeding frequency drops — they were good for you independently of how much milk your body was making.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Suji upma with vegetables (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Besara, mustard-based vegetable curry (1 cup) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a masoor dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Odia fish curry (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a besara vegetable side

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut papaya
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a toor dal (3/4 cup) and a carrot santula
- B. Egg curry, Odia-style (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a carrot santula

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 3 — Appetite changes don't need to be managed anxiously

Some days you may find you're just not as hungry as you were during heavier nursing months. Trusting that shift, rather than forcing a fixed intake out of habit, is reasonable — the target now is eating enough to match your own body's signals, not replicating an earlier phase's numbers.

Worth knowing: A noticeable drop in appetite as nursing reduces is common and not usually a cause for concern on its own. If appetite loss is severe, persistent, or comes with other symptoms that worry you, it's worth mentioning to your healthcare team rather than assuming it will simply pass.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Poda pitha with jaggery (2 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg sandwich (2 eggs, 2 slices bread) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup) and a dalma (1 cup)

B. Chicken curry, Odia-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans santula

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a guava

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few dates

Dinner — choose one:

A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a spinach santula

B. Paneer-and-tomato curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach santula

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 4 — Calcium habits stay worth keeping either way

Calcium needs stay elevated through breastfeeding and don't disappear the moment nursing frequency drops — and a dependable calcium habit built now, through curd, milk or paneer, is a good one to keep for your own bone health well beyond this phase, not just for as long as you're nursing.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Pakhala, fermented rice with curd (1 cup) with a boiled egg

B. Egg-and-vegetable omelette (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Dalma with lauki (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked toor dal) with rice (1 cup cooked)

B. Egg curry, Odia-style (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bhindi santula

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a pear

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted walnuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with an urad dal (3/4 cup) and a lauki santula

B. Chicken curry, Odia-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a lauki santula

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 5 — No need to abruptly overhaul how you eat

It's tempting to treat a change in feeding frequency as a cue to suddenly change your diet — cutting portions sharply, for instance. There's no need to overhaul anything abruptly; a gradual, appetite-led adjustment over the coming weeks is a reasonable, comfortable pace.

Breakfast — choose one:

A. Poda pitha with grated coconut (2 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)

B. Egg-and-vegetable sandwich (2 eggs, 2 slices bread) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

A. Besara with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and rice (1 cup cooked)

B. Odia machha jhola (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cauliflower santula

Nourishment break — choose one:

A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with an orange

B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted makhana (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup) and a bhindi santula

B. Egg curry, Odia-style (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a lauki santula

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 6 — The pattern across this transition matters, not one day's appetite

Some days appetite may feel almost like before, other days noticeably less — both are a normal part of this transition, and neither needs to be corrected in the moment. What matters over these weeks is that your overall eating stays varied and includes protein and calcium regularly, whatever the day-to-day appetite looks like.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Suji upma with grated carrot (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-onion bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a dalma (1 cup)
- B. Chicken curry, Odia-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cauliflower santula

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut watermelon
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted cashews (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Moong dal-and-vegetable khichdi (1 1/2 cups total, made with a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong dal, plus carrots and peas) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg curry, Odia-style (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach santula

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 7 — A repeat-favourites day

No forced choices today. Day 1's combination is repeated below as a ready option — or swap in whichever meals from earlier in the week worked best for you.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Poda pitha, fermented rice cake (2 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Dalma, dal with vegetables (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked toor dal) with rice (1 cup cooked)
- B. Paneer-and-tomato curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a dalma (1 cup)

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a cabbage santula
- B. Chicken curry, Odia-style (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage santula

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Has your appetite noticeably shifted as feeding frequency has changed, and how has that felt to adjust to?

Gentle weekly reflection

What's one small habit from this week — a food, a routine — that felt worth keeping, without needing to overhaul everything at once?

Looking ahead

The next set of weeks continues this series' steady, one-topic-at-a-time approach to your own nutrition and wellbeing.

Food safety basics

- Cook meat, poultry and fish to a safe internal temperature rather than judging by colour alone — check with a food thermometer where practical: whole cuts of beef, pork, veal or lamb to at least 63°C, followed by three minutes' rest; ground meat to at least 71°C; poultry, including ground poultry, to at least 74°C; and fish to at least 63°C. Avoid runny yolks.
- Use pasteurized dairy only.
- Wash fruits and vegetables thoroughly before eating.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. Boiling can reduce microbial risk, but it does not remove fluoride or other dissolved chemicals. If fluoride or another chemical contaminant is a concern, use a water source or treatment method confirmed as suitable by the local water authority or a recognised laboratory.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding or could be pregnant, unless your healthcare team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding, and no amount of alcohol is known to be safe if you're pregnant or could be. If you choose to drink while breastfeeding and not pregnant, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose fish from the FDA/EPA "Best Choices" list and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.

NOURISH — Postpartum

Phase 5 of 6 — Beyond the first year

Postpartum Week 143

DRAFT v1 — for review, not yet locked

Weekly nourishment theme

Eating gently through a genuinely hard stretch

"Grief or a difficult stretch can make food feel unimportant, or appetite disappear almost entirely — that's a normal response, not a problem to fix immediately. Small, low-pressure amounts, more often than usual, are enough for now."

Why it matters now

This week's content is here for whenever it's needed, not necessarily this week. A loss, a difficult diagnosis affecting someone close to you, or another genuinely hard stretch can make food feel unimportant or appetite disappear almost entirely — a normal, temporary response to real distress, not a failure of self-care.

The aim during a stretch like this isn't a full, balanced week of meals — it's small, manageable amounts, more often than usual, and letting the return to your usual eating happen gradually, on your own timeline.

If a medical condition affects your meals

If you manage diabetes or another condition affecting blood sugar: a prolonged drop in intake can affect blood sugar control — contact your care team if appetite loss continues for more than a few days.

If you have PCOS: flexible, balanced eating across the week matters more than any single "PCOS diet" — there's no special curative diet required, and the general guidance in this series applies to you too.

If you take levothyroxine or another daily medication: try to keep taking it on schedule even on days when eating is difficult — ask your pharmacist if a very light intake affects timing.

If appetite loss lasts more than a couple of weeks, or comes with significant weight loss or feelings that worry you: reach out to your healthcare team or a counsellor — this is common, and support is available.

These notes are general starting points, not condition-specific menus — the meal options below aren't matched to any particular condition's nutrient or carbohydrate targets. Individual guidance from your own care team always takes precedence.

If you eat meat, fish, or eggs

Meat, fish and eggs can all sit comfortably in a regular week's meals here, in whatever small amount feels manageable. If you are pregnant or breastfeeding and eat fish, FDA/EPA guidance recommends two to three adult servings weekly from its "Best Choices" list — about 113 g per serving before cooking, though this week's portions are intentionally smaller. Follow local advisories. This is an option for fish eaters, not a requirement to add fish.

Using the meals below

Choose either option, not both — these are alternatives, not two separate meals. Repeating a combination you already managed earlier in the week is completely fine. Portions this week are intentionally smaller than usual, reflecting that a reduced appetite is the expected starting point, not a lapse to correct — eat more if you're able to, and don't worry if you can only manage a little. If nothing here appeals, plain curd, a banana, or a glass of milk are all reasonable meals on their own on a hard day. The "A" options are vegetarian, prepared with vegetable stock or water rather than meat or fish stock, including this week's regional dishes.

A cup means a standard 240ml measuring cup. This week's smaller portions are a deliberate, gentler starting point — scale up freely as your appetite allows, and don't treat these amounts as a ceiling once you're feeling more able to eat. In a mixed rice or grain dish, the meat, fish, paneer or legume component is roughly 75g of that ingredient, counted separately from the grain itself.

Paneer, tofu, meat or fish eaten as a dish's main item is about 75g cooked this week, or one egg — these are different foods with different nutrient content, and are not nutritionally interchangeable just because they share a similar portion size. Curd or milk is a small bowl or glass (150-200ml); nuts or seeds used as a topping are about a tablespoon (roughly 10-15g).

The meals contribute different nutrients across the day; each individual meal or snack does not need to include every food group, and this week especially, something is better than an empty plate. Where you can manage it, include a dependable protein source and a dependable calcium source — curd, milk or paneer — at more than one point in the day. If you avoid dairy, calcium-fortified alternatives or calcium-set tofu are options, checking the label. Adults generally need about 1,000 mg of calcium a day, including while breastfeeding — a single measured serving is a helpful building block, not the whole day's requirement on its own. Food choices alone don't rule out a need for supplementation — ask your own clinician what's right for you.

This week's meals draw on Himachali/Pahari home cooking (siddu, madra, chana madra, and similar). If a regional dish is unfamiliar, unavailable, or simply too much effort right now, choose whatever familiar, easy food fills a similar role: dal or curd for protein and calcium, and rice or a soft grain for the base. Keep it simple this week — that's the point.

Day 1 — Anchor

A loss, a hard diagnosis in the family, or another genuinely difficult stretch can blunt appetite almost completely for a while — food may feel unimportant, or simply hard to face. That's a normal, temporary response to real distress, not something wrong with you. The aim on days like these isn't a full, balanced plate — it's small amounts that are easy to manage.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Siddu, steamed wheat bun (1 piece) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. A boiled egg with toast (1 slice) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Chana madra, chickpeas in a yoghurt gravy (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked chickpeas) with rice (1/2 cup cooked)
- B. A small portion of Pahari-style chicken curry (75g chicken) with rice (1/2 cup cooked)

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. A glass of milk (200ml)

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Khichdi, plain rice and moong dal (1 cup total) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. A boiled egg with khichdi, plain rice and moong dal (1 cup total)

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g), whenever you feel able to manage it

Day 2 — Small and frequent, rather than three full meals

If a full plate feels like too much right now, smaller amounts spaced more often through the day can be easier to manage than forcing three complete meals. A few spoonfuls of dal and rice, a glass of milk, a banana — these all count, and there's no need to "catch up" on a skipped meal later.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. A banana with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Toast (1 slice) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Madra, vegetables in a yoghurt gravy (1 cup) with rice (1/2 cup cooked) and a masoor dal (1/2 cup)
- B. Pahari trout, pan-cooked (75g fish) with rice (1/2 cup cooked)

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small cup of buttermilk (150ml)
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few roasted almonds (15g)

Dinner — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of moong dal (1/2 cup) with rice (1/2 cup cooked)
- B. A boiled egg with rice (1/2 cup cooked) and a small bowl of moong dal (1/2 cup)

If you're still hungry: A glass of milk (200ml), whenever you feel able to manage it

Day 3 — When to mention it to your healthcare team

Most appetite loss after a hard event eases gradually on its own. If it's stretching on for weeks, or you're finding it hard to eat almost anything at all, that's worth raising with a doctor or counsellor rather than waiting it out indefinitely — especially while breastfeeding, when your own intake also matters for your baby.

Worth knowing: A loss of appetite lasting more than a couple of weeks, or accompanied by significant weight loss, an inability to keep any food down, or feelings that worry you, is worth mentioning to your healthcare team — support is available, and reaching out isn't a failure to manage on your own.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Siddu with ghee (1 piece) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. A boiled egg with toast (1 slice) and a small bowl of curd (150g)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rice (1/2 cup cooked) with a masoor dal (1/2 cup) and a small portion of madra
- B. A small portion of Pahari-style chicken curry (75g chicken) with rice (1/2 cup cooked) and a cucumber salad

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g), on its own
- B. A small glass of milk (150ml)

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1/2 cup cooked) with a chana dal (1/2 cup)
- B. A boiled egg with rice (1/2 cup cooked) and a chana dal (1/2 cup)

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g), whenever you feel able to manage it

Day 4 — Letting someone else help with food, if that's available

If family or friends are offering to cook or bring food during a hard stretch, accepting that help is a reasonable, practical choice, not a burden you're placing on them. It's one less decision to make on a day when even small decisions can feel like a lot.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Whatever's offered or easiest today — a small bowl of curd (150g) alongside it is a reasonable addition
- B. Whatever's offered or easiest today, with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Chana madra (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked chickpeas) with rice (1/2 cup cooked)
- B. Pahari trout (75g fish) with rice (1/2 cup cooked)

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g), with a pinch of roasted cumin if that helps
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few roasted walnuts (15g)

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1/2 cup cooked) with a moong dal (1/2 cup)
- B. A small portion of Pahari-style chicken curry (75g chicken) with a phulka (1 piece)

If you're still hungry: A glass of milk (200ml), whenever you feel able to manage it

Day 5 — Gently returning toward your usual pattern, when you're ready

There's no fixed timeline for appetite to return to normal after a hard stretch — for some it's days, for others longer, and that's fine either way. When you do notice hunger coming back, easing toward your usual meals rather than a full return all at once tends to feel more manageable.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Siddu (1 piece) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. A boiled egg with a small bowl of curd (150g)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Madra (1 cup) with rice (3/4 cup cooked) and a masoor dal (1/2 cup)
- B. Fish curry, Pahari-style (75g fish) with rice (3/4 cup cooked)

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a piece of seasonal fruit
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted makhana (15g)

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (3/4 cup cooked) with a masoor dal (1/2 cup) and a spinach sabzi
- B. A boiled egg with rice (3/4 cup cooked) and a spinach sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 6 — Some days will still be harder than others

Even as things gradually feel more manageable, some days — an anniversary, a reminder, an unexpectedly hard moment — may bring appetite loss back briefly. That's a normal part of grief and doesn't mean you've lost the progress you've made. The same gentle, small-and-frequent approach still works on those days.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Suji upma, small portion (1/2 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. A boiled egg with a small glass of milk (150ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rice (3/4 cup cooked) with a chana dal (1/2 cup) and a madra vegetable side
- B. A small portion of Pahari-style chicken curry (75g chicken) with rice (3/4 cup cooked)

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) — whatever amount feels manageable
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few dates

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Moong dal-and-rice khichdi (1 cup total, made with a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong dal) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. A boiled egg with rice (3/4 cup cooked) and a chana dal (1/2 cup)

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g), whenever you feel able to manage it

Day 7 — A repeat-favourites day

No forced choices today. Day 1's combination is repeated below as a ready option — or whatever felt most manageable earlier in the week.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Siddu, steamed wheat bun (1 piece) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. A boiled egg with toast (1 slice) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Chana madra, chickpeas in a yoghurt gravy (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked chickpeas) with rice (1/2 cup cooked)
- B. A small portion of Pahari-style chicken curry (75g chicken) with rice (1/2 cup cooked)

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. A glass of milk (200ml)

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Khichdi, plain rice and moong dal (1 cup total) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. A boiled egg with khichdi, plain rice and moong dal (1 cup total)

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g), whenever you feel able to manage it

Is there someone — family, a friend, your healthcare team — you could let help with food or check in with, if this week has been genuinely hard?

Gentle weekly reflection

If this week wasn't a hard one, is there someone in your life going through a difficult stretch who this gentle, low-pressure approach to eating might help, even just to share?

Looking ahead

The next set of weeks returns to this series' steady, one-topic-at-a-time approach to your own nutrition and wellbeing.

Food safety basics

- Cook meat, poultry and fish to a safe internal temperature rather than judging by colour alone — check with a food thermometer where practical: whole cuts of beef, pork, veal or lamb to at least 63°C, followed by three minutes' rest; ground meat to at least 71°C; poultry, including ground poultry, to at least 74°C; and fish to at least 63°C. Avoid runny yolks.
- Use pasteurized dairy only.
- Wash fruits and vegetables thoroughly before eating.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. Boiling can reduce microbial risk, but it does not remove fluoride or other dissolved chemicals. If fluoride or another chemical contaminant is a concern, use a water source or treatment method confirmed as suitable by the local water authority or a recognised laboratory.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding or could be pregnant, unless your healthcare team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding, and no amount of alcohol is known to be safe if you're pregnant or could be. If you choose to drink while breastfeeding and not pregnant, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose fish from the FDA/EPA "Best Choices" list and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.

NOURISH — Postpartum

Phase 5 of 6 — Beyond the first year

Postpartum Week 144

DRAFT v1 — for review, not yet locked

Weekly nourishment theme

Taking stock — building your own simple, personal usual week

"Not every habit from this series needed to stick, and that's fine — what's worth keeping now is whatever actually fits your life, turned into your own simple, personal routine rather than something you have to keep following."

Why it matters now

This series has now covered a wide range of weekly topics — from the earliest days of recovery through toddlerhood and the everyday realities of feeding a household. This week is deliberately different: a chance to look back at what's actually stuck, rather than take on something new.

Not every suggestion from every week was ever meant to become a permanent habit — some were seasonal, some simply didn't fit, and some quietly became part of how you eat without you noticing. This week is about noticing that, and building your own simple, personal sense of what a normal week of eating looks like for you now.

If a medical condition affects your meals

If you manage diabetes or another condition affecting blood sugar: keep following your own care team's specific guidance on portions and timing going forward — the A and B meal options here aren't matched for carbohydrate content either.

If you have PCOS: flexible, balanced eating across the week matters more than any single "PCOS diet" — there's no special curative diet required, and the general guidance in this series applies to you too.

If you take levothyroxine or another ongoing medication: keep whatever timing routine around meals and calcium or iron supplements has been working for you — check in with your pharmacist if anything about that routine changes.

These notes are general starting points, not condition-specific menus — the meal options below aren't matched to any particular condition's nutrient or carbohydrate targets. Individual guidance from your own care team always takes precedence.

If you eat meat, fish, or eggs

Meat, fish and eggs can all sit comfortably in a regular week's meals here. If you are pregnant or breastfeeding and eat fish, FDA/EPA guidance recommends two to three adult servings weekly from its "Best Choices" list — about 113 g per serving before cooking. Follow local advisories. This is an option for fish eaters, not a requirement to add fish.

Using the meals below

Choose either option, not both — these are alternatives, not two separate meals. Repeating a combination you already enjoyed earlier in the week is completely fine. If nothing here appeals or you'd rather keep it simple, reheated dal, rice and curd is an option if it suits your dietary needs and any care plan you follow. The "if you're still hungry" suggestions are suggestions, not limits — adjust everything to your own appetite; this week's meals are meant to be adequate, not restrictive. The "A" options are vegetarian, prepared with vegetable stock or water rather than meat or fish stock, including this week's regional dishes.

Portions below are adjustable starting points, not maximum allowances — scale to your own appetite, activity and any care plan you follow. A cup means a standard 240ml measuring cup. Unless a dish says otherwise: rice or another cooked grain eaten on its own is one level cup (about 150g); a dal, bean or lentil curry eaten as its own dish is three-quarters of a cup cooked (about 150g); a roti is one medium piece; toast is 2 slices. In a mixed rice or grain dish, the meat, fish, paneer or legume component is about 75-100g of that ingredient (roughly a palm-sized piece, or half a cup of cooked legumes), counted separately from the grain itself.

Paneer, tofu, meat or fish eaten as a dish's main item is 75-100g cooked (a palm-sized piece), or two eggs — these are different foods with different nutrient content, and are not nutritionally interchangeable just because they share a similar portion size. Curd or milk is a small bowl or glass (150-200ml); a cooked vegetable side is about a cup; nuts or seeds used as a topping are about a tablespoon (roughly 10-15g).

The meals contribute different nutrients across the day; each individual meal or snack does not need to include every food group. Choose varied meals through the day and include a dependable protein source and a dependable calcium source at more than one meal — curd, milk or paneer — rather than relying on trace amounts in mixed dishes or an optional extra. If you avoid dairy, include measured portions of calcium-fortified alternatives or calcium-set tofu, checking the label. Adults generally need about 1,000 mg of calcium a day — a single measured serving is a helpful building block, not the whole day's requirement on its own. Food choices alone don't rule out a need for supplementation — ask your own clinician what's right for you.

This week's meals draw on Malvani/coastal Maharashtrian home cooking (solkadhi, kalvan, usal, and similar). If a regional dish is unfamiliar or unavailable, choose a familiar alternative with a similar nutritional role: dal or beans for a legume dish, a suitable protein source for a protein dish, and vegetables for a vegetable side. Keep the grain portion and any planned calcium source. These swaps are not nutritionally identical.

Day 1 — Anchor

This series has covered a lot of ground — this week is a chance to look back rather than learn something new. Some habits from earlier weeks probably stuck without much effort; others may never have fit your life, and that's completely fine. Neither outcome reflects on how well you've been doing.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Sanna, steamed rice cakes (2 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Usal, sprouted moth bean curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked moth beans) with rice (1 cup cooked)
- B. Paneer-and-tomato curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and an usal (1 cup)

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a cabbage sabzi
- B. Chicken kalvan, coconut-based chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 2 — Which habits actually stuck, without effort?

Think back over the past weeks — is there a food or a small routine that's just become part of how you eat now, without you having to remind yourself? Those effortless habits are usually the ones worth building your ongoing routine around, since they've already proven they fit.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Suji upma with vegetables (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg bhurji, spiced scrambled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Kalvan, coconut-based vegetable curry (1 cup) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a chana dal (3/4 cup)
- B. Malvani fish curry (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a beans sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut papaya
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted almonds (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a toor dal (3/4 cup) and a spinach sabzi
- B. Egg curry, Malvani-style (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a spinach sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 3 — Letting go of what didn't fit, without guilt

Some things this series suggested probably didn't stick, whether because they didn't suit your taste, your schedule, or your household. That's useful information, not a shortcoming — it simply tells you what to leave out of your own ongoing routine going forward.

Worth knowing: If a particular habit from this series never worked for your life — a food you don't enjoy, a routine your schedule can't support — letting it go isn't a failure. The goal was always to find what's sustainable for you, not to adopt every suggestion.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Sanna with jaggery (2 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg sandwich (2 eggs, 2 slices bread) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup) and a kalvan vegetable side
- B. Chicken kalvan (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cauliflower sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a guava
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with a few dates

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a carrot sabzi
- B. Paneer-and-peas curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a carrot sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 4 — The two or three non-negotiables worth keeping

Out of everything this series has covered, most people find just two or three habits genuinely worth protecting long-term — a dependable calcium source most days, eating something before you're overly hungry, or not skipping meals entirely on busy days, for instance. Naming your own two or three, specifically, makes them easier to actually keep.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Poha, flattened rice with vegetables (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-vegetable omelette (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Usal with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and rice (1 cup cooked)
- B. Egg curry, Malvani-style (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a lauki sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a pear
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted walnuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with an urad dal (3/4 cup) and a lauki sabzi
- B. Chicken kalvan (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a lauki sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 5 — A simple 'usual week' template, in your own words

Rather than a new theme to follow, try sketching what an ordinary week of eating now actually looks like for you — your real breakfasts, your real lunches, the snacks you reach for. That's your own baseline going forward, built from what's actually worked, not a list to aspire to.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Sanna with grated coconut (2 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-vegetable sandwich (2 eggs, 2 slices bread) with a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Kalvan with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and rice (1 cup cooked)
- B. Malvani fish fry with a light curry (100g fish) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cauliflower sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with an orange
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted makhana (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a masoor dal (3/4 cup) and a bhindi sabzi
- B. Egg curry, Malvani-style (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a bhindi sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 6 — Trusting yourself going forward

By now you likely know your own appetite, your own schedule, and your own household's needs better than any weekly theme could account for. That knowledge is the real outcome of this series — not perfect adherence to any single week's suggestions, but a working sense of what keeps you fed well, most of the time.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Suji upma with grated carrot (1 cup) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg-and-onion bhurji (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a chana dal (3/4 cup) and a kalvan vegetable side
- B. Chicken kalvan (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a cup of cut watermelon
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted cashews (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Moong dal-and-vegetable khichdi (1 1/2 cups total, made with a measured 1/2 cup cooked rice and a measured 1/2 cup cooked moong dal, plus carrots and peas) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Egg curry, Malvani-style (2 eggs) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cauliflower sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Day 7 — A repeat-favourites day

No forced choices today. Day 1's combination is repeated below as a ready option — or better yet, whatever your own 'usual week' looks like by now.

Breakfast — choose one:

- A. Sanna, steamed rice cakes (2 pieces) with a small bowl of curd (150g)
- B. Boiled eggs (2 eggs) with toast (2 slices) and a glass of milk (200ml)

Lunch — choose one:

- A. Usal, sprouted moth bean curry (1 cup, includes a measured 1/2 cup cooked moth beans) with rice (1 cup cooked)
- B. Paneer-and-tomato curry (100g paneer) with rice (1 cup cooked) and an usal (1 cup)

Nourishment break — choose one:

- A. A small bowl of curd (150g) with a banana
- B. A glass of milk (200ml) with roasted peanuts (15g) and a piece of seasonal fruit

Dinner — choose one:

- A. Rice (1 cup cooked) with a moong dal (3/4 cup) and a cabbage sabzi
- B. Chicken kalvan, coconut-based chicken curry (100g chicken) with rice (1 cup cooked) and a cabbage sabzi

If you're still hungry: A small bowl of curd (150g)

Looking back across this whole series, what's the one habit you'd tell another mother to keep, if she only had time for one?

Gentle weekly reflection

What's one small habit from this week — a food, a routine — that felt worth keeping, without needing to overhaul everything at once?

Looking ahead

Future weeks in this series will continue occasionally, at the same steady, one-topic-at-a-time pace — but your own routine, built over these past weeks, is now the foundation to return to.

Food safety basics

- Cook meat, poultry and fish to a safe internal temperature rather than judging by colour alone — check with a food thermometer where practical: whole cuts of beef, pork, veal or lamb to at least 63°C, followed by three minutes' rest; ground meat to at least 71°C; poultry, including ground poultry, to at least 74°C; and fish to at least 63°C. Avoid runny yolks.
- Use pasteurized dairy only.
- Wash fruits and vegetables thoroughly before eating.
- Use reliably safe drinking water. Boiling can reduce microbial risk, but it does not remove fluoride or other dissolved chemicals. If fluoride or another chemical contaminant is a concern, use a water source or treatment method confirmed as suitable by the local water authority or a recognised laboratory.
- Keep total caffeine under 200 mg a day if you're breastfeeding or could be pregnant, unless your healthcare team advises otherwise.
- Not drinking alcohol is the safest option while breastfeeding, and no amount of alcohol is known to be safe if you're pregnant or could be. If you choose to drink while breastfeeding and not pregnant, allow at least two hours per standard drink before breastfeeding, and make sure a sober adult is available to care for the baby.
- Refrigerate cooked food promptly, and reheat leftovers until steaming hot, not just warm.
- Choose fish from the FDA/EPA "Best Choices" list and cook it fully — two to three servings a week from varied types is a commonly used guideline, following any local advisories.